

IN THE FIGHT Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray at a public meeting in Solapur, Apr. 29

RAJU SANADI

ployment, farmer suicides (are)."

Something else syncs with the irony of the Sena critiquing Hindutva. In the late '80s and early '90s, the Sena had come to be the vanguard of Hindutva in Maharashtra—transitioning from an organisation that represented Marathi speakers in Mumbai. But leaders from the Muslim community—around 14 per cent of the state's population, with a significant urban concentration—say that, in a break with the past, the 'majority of the minority' will vote for the Sena (UBT) to defeat the BJP in one-on-one fights. Uddhav's attempts to "secularise" the party have evidently helped, especially the memory of the MVA's crackdown on the developers of the Bullibai app, which launched mock online auctions of Muslim women. "The Muslim vote is anti-BJP, it will go with any MVA constituent even though there's not even a single Muslim candidate," says an MVA leader. The Marathi-Muslim combination forms over 50 per cent of the electorate in Mumbai and the Greater Mumbai region, where the Sena (UBT) is contesting a major chunk of the seats, he says.

An NCP leader also believes that in the absence of a larger voter consolidation, the situation is fluid from seat to seat. The agitation by activist Manoj Jarange Patil for OBC quotas for the Marathas is said to have led to restiveness among the backward classes, who are unifying against Maratha candidates, especially in seats like Parbhani in Marathwada. Many admit a goodish section of subaltern voters have bought into the fear—sparked by comments from the BJP side and fanned by the Congress—that the BJP will do away with reservations for the Dalits, tribals and OBCs if it returns to power. This is not a light topic anywhere, least of all in a state known for its Dalit mobilisation and non-Brahmin movements. No wonder senior BJP leaders, including Union home minister Amit Shah, have been scurrying for damage control.

OBSERVERS SPEAK OF POPULAR SYMPATHY FOR UDDHAV, A RIGHTFUL INHERITOR WHO HAD BEEN WRONGED. THE NCP SPLIT ONLY APPEARED TO SHARPEN THAT PERCEPTION

In an election dominated by emotion, grittier issues linked to farmers, farm labour and the unemployed may be fading away. "In Vidarbha and Marathwada, there's little industrial development and hence, no option to agriculture," says Vijay Jawandhia of the Shetkari Sanghatana. But it's a volatile existence: cotton rates have fallen from Rs 12,000 a quintal two years ago to Rs 7,000 now, and onion exports were banned when it was fetching good prices. "Unlike farmers in Punjab and the north, those in Vidarbha lack the resources to protest due to their marginal holdings and rainfed, single-crop land," he adds. Former MLA and activist Vivek Pandit, who leads the Shramajeevi Sanghatana, says well-intentioned schemes like the Jal Jeevan Mission have floundered due to corruption. "The BJP has not ensured its implementation and the Opposition has not spoken about it," he says. "The public healthcare in rural areas is in a shambles, and issues related to education have taken a backseat." A sarpanch from a village in western Maharashtra too talks of how rural earnings have stagnated and laments that these issues do not figure in the political discourse.

Summing up the mood, journalist and analyst Hemant Desai says: "You cannot feel any Modi wave; instead, there seems to be a subterranean wave against the BJP." The final word, though, comes from a veteran west Maharashtra politician. "It is the silent voters who forge miracles," he says. "We study for the examinations, but the voters set the paper and check the answersheets too." ■